

music festival

Mystic Melodies

NAGAU In days gone by, Nagaur in Rajasthan was an important centre of Sufi saints. From Hameem-uddeen Rehani to Sheikh Fareeduddeen Naguari and Khwaja Hussain Nagauri, famous Sufi saints not only taught and shared spiritual truths regardless of the religious differences but also added to the richness of the musical tradition of the town with their power-packed qawwalis. It was a quaint mingling of royal heritage and spiritual fervour of the Sufis.

To rekindle this tradition, a two-day festival organised by Banyan Tree takes off on February 9 at the 800-year-old spectacular Nagaur Fort. The festival will feature exponents of some of the most beautiful and rare living musical traditions through which Sufism expressed itself in this rich land vibrating with most unusual musical frequencies from countries like India, Turkey, Egypt and Iran.

The first day features folk music from Rajasthan

followed by Laltif Bolat from Turkey. Ustad Shujaat Khan of Imdad Khan gharana plays the sitar and performs Sufi songs. His recital will be followed by Sufi qawwalis by Shameem-Nayeem Ajmeri and his group.

Hafiza Begum and her group from Assam perform on the second day, a reminder that Sufi music and traditions exist even in our eastern states. She will be followed by Barkat Siddhu, another Sufi singer from Punjab, who is a fine exponent of the Patiala gharana. Next is a qawwali performance by the Nizami brothers and traditional Sufi songs by Sheikh Yassin Eltohami and a group from Egypt.

The performances are a rare treat as qawwali is fast disappearing from today's concert circuit, with preference being given to indipop and other forms of new-age music. For those wishing to stay overnight at the fort, accommodation will be available in royal tents. The festival takes place under the star lit skies inside the fort, bringing alive the mystique of a bygone era.

by S. Sahaya Ranjit

RARE TREAT: The Nizami brothers bring Sufi songs alive



exhibition

Back in Time

DELHI The Photograph: Painted, Posed and of the Moment is a maiden venture of India Photo Now '08, an Indo-European platform for showcasing photography in India. Divided into four sections, it displays works by Henri Cartier-Bresson, Magnum Photos, Umrao Singh Sher-Gil and the Alkazi Collection of Photography. Connoisseurs can look forward to Bresson's legendary and lesser known images, along with archival images from Magnum Photos which began in 1947. While Magnum's images outline India by 14 photographers, Sher-Gil's photos (largely self-portraits) are from 1889 to 1949. The Alkazi Collection shows religious, cultural and courtly life in the princely states in late 19th and early 20th century India along with scenes from towns and the British Raj. In Delhi from January 27-February 13 at National Gallery of Modern Art; Mumbai (February 29 to March 21) and at Rabindranath Tagore Centre in Kolkata (May 8 onwards).

by Newly Paul

NOSTALGIC: Amrita Sher-Gil as shot by her father Umrao Singh



art

Optical Illusion

MUMBAI Inspired by poet Jibanananda Das's works, Samir Mondal's collection of watercolours—Dhusar Pandulipi: The Faded Manuscript—is the artist's latest collection where he addresses the rhetoric and paints the encounters of the human body with emotions. The works create an optical illusion of



Mondal's watercolour depth and excel in delicacy and detail. The images are layered, illustrating nuances. At Jehangir Art Gallery till February 4; then at Jamaat Gallery till March 5.